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Moral Judgements

What does it mean to declare something “good” or “bad”?

Are there objective criteria for these judgements or are they merely subjective?

In the modern era, people often reject absolute authority. Hence, modern society loses the traditional foundation for universal moral rules.

Nietzsche and Foucault considered the concept of “Man” as historically constructed. This implies that there is no universal, unchanging human nature.

Theories Of Moral Judgement

Non-Cognitivism (Emotivism)

Moral judgements are expressions of emotions.

They are merely personal preferences or subjective points of view.

Only factual statements can be strictly true or false, whereas morality operates in the domain of motivation (to act on personal preferences rather than objective facts).

The criticism for this theory is that it confuses expression of preferences with expression of evaluation.

Cognitivism

Moral judgements are evaluative expressions that can be categorised as true or false based on specific evaluative criteria.

For example, “cheating is wrong” can be evaluated as true because the act violates the dignity of a person.

Kant and MacIntyre argue against pure subjectivity, noting that even in art, there is judgement where broad consensus and agreement are demanded.

If even art, a field people assume is entirely subjective, actually requires rational judgement, criteria and consensus, then morality definitely requires it too.

- “I like this painting” vs “This painting is a masterpiece”

MacIntyre argues that stating “right” or “wrong” requires rational inquiry and is fundamentally different from the personal preference of approval.

Within cognitivism, philosophers are divided on what kind of facts make these statements true.

■ Naturalism (MacIntyre, Aristotle)

Moral properties like “goodness” or “rightness” are natural features of the world. Morality is grounded in human nature, meaning ethical truths can be observed and analysed like scientific facts.

A “good human” is simply one who successfully fulfills their natural function, which is to achieve human flourishing or well-being. “Goodness” is tied to observable, natural facts like physical health, psychological continuity, and social harmony.

■ Non-Naturalism (Moore)

Moral properties are objective (true or false) but they cannot be reduced to or equated with physical, natural properties like pleasure, happiness or survival.

According to Moore, we do not discover moral truths through scientific observation of human nature, but through moral intuition.

The Moral Agent

A moral agent is an individual who is capable of making moral judgements and being held responsible for them.

To be considered a moral agent, an individual must possess three characteristics:

- **Psychological continuity:** a persistent sense of self over time, allowing accountability for past actions
- **Reflective capacity:** ability to think about, evaluate and choose actions based on reasoning
- **Be a social being:** must exist and interact within a social context or community

Telos (Purpose)

MacIntyre provides a functional definition of “good” based on an entity’s **telos**, meaning its inherent purpose or expected function.

A knife’s function is to cut, so a “good knife” is one that cuts well.

A “good engineer” or a “good farmer” is one who successfully does what they are expected to do.

Like plants and animals, humans have a telos.

A human’s purpose is to achieve well-being and happiness, which is distinct from mere pleasure.

Therefore, a “good human” is defined as someone who actively moves towards well-being.

[MacIntyre] Moral Disagreement and Emotivism

Interminability of Modern Moral Debate

MacIntyre states that contemporary moral language is in a state of disorder, functioning as a “masquerade” of rational argument that conceals a reality of arbitrary personal preference.

He identifies the “interminable” character of contemporary moral disagreements. These debates are not merely long-lasting; they lack any rational “terminus” or method for securing agreement.

Three Case Studies

■ War and Pacifism

- War is only just if “the good to be achieved outweighs the evils involved” and if we can distinguish between “combatants and non-combatants”. However, modern wars easily escalate and innocent civilians are inevitably killed, so “no modern war can be a just war”.
- “If you wish for peace, prepare for war”.
- Wars between global powers are destructive, but “wars waged to liberate oppressed groups are a necessary and therefore justified means” to end exploitation and bring about happiness.

Justice and Innocence -> National survival -> Liberation

■ Abortion

- Everybody has certain rights over his or her person, including his or her own body.
- “I cannot will that my mother should have had an abortion when she was pregnant with me. Therefore, to be logically consistent, I cannot deny the right to life to others.”
- “If infanticide is murder, as it is, abortion is murder.”

Individual rights -> Universalizability -> Absolute right to life

■ Healthcare and Education

- “Every citizen should enjoy, as far as possible, an equal opportunity to develop his or her talents”, hence private schools and private medical practices should be abolished.
- “Everybody has a right to incur such and only such obligations as he or she wishes.”

Equality -> Liberty

Conceptual Incommensurability

The primary reason these debates cannot be resolved is conceptual incommensurability. While each argument is logically valid (the conclusions follow from the premises), the rival premises use different normative or evaluative concepts that cannot be compared on a single rational scale.

The Paradox of Modern Moral Language

Our words pretend to appeal to objective, rational, and impersonal standards that apply to everyone. In reality, because we have lost any shared rational standards, we are actually doing nothing more than expressing our private feelings and trying to manipulate the emotions and behaviours of others.

- “Because I wish it” = depends on personal context whether this has reason-giving force
- “Because it is your duty / Because it would give pleasure to a number of people” = independent of who utters it and presupposes the existence of impersonal criteria

The fact that we still use this language shows that our culture retains at least an aspiration to be or to become rational in this area of our lives.

The person speaking is often the first victim of their own masquerade. They assure themselves that they are appealing to independent standards, when all that they are in fact doing is expressing their feelings to others in a manipulative way.

Failure of Emotivism

Emotivism fails to account for the difference between an expression of personal preference (context-dependent) and a moral judgement (which purports to be context-independent).

MacIntyre states that emotivism is a false theory of meaning, but it is a highly accurate description of how modern people actually use moral language today.

MacIntyre’s central claim is that we live in a “specifically emotivist culture” where moral language is used to manipulate others through the appearance of a rationality that no longer exists in substance.

Nature of Moral Judgment (Descriptive vs. Evaluative)

Descriptive judgements report empirical facts, states of affairs, and observed behaviours about how the world is without prescribing moral worth.

Evaluative / normative judgements establish values and duties about what is good, bad, right, or how agents ought to act.

[Elliot Sober] Psychological Egoism

Psychological egoism is a theory about motivation that claims all of our ultimate desires are self-directed. Whenever we want others to do well (or ill), we have these other-directed desires only instrumentally; we care about others only because we think that the welfare of others will have ramifications for our own welfare. Humans ultimately look for their self-interest and all our acts including altruism are motivated by self-interest.

Egoism is a descriptive, not a normative, claim.

- An **instrumental desire** is a desire for something not for its own sake, but only as a means to acquiring something else.
- An **ultimate desire** is a desire for something for its own sake and for reasons that go beyond its ability to contribute instrumentally to the attainment of something else.

The alternative to Psychological Egoism is Motivational Pluralism, which is the theory that human beings possess both egoistic and altruistic ultimate desires. To defeat egoism, you do not need to prove that humans are purely altruistic; you only need to show that sometimes we act from both ultimate self-directed and other-directed reasons.

The Truisms

Sober points out two simple truths that people often confuse with evidence for egoism.

1. Who owns the desire vs. What the desire is about

“Because it’s my mind wanting something, my desire must be selfish.”

Sober corrects that the fact that Joe acts on Joe’s desires tells us whose mind holds the desire, but it tells us nothing about whether the goal inside Joe’s head is self-interested or altruistic.

2. Getting what you want vs. Feeling good afterward

“When you get what you want, you feel satisfied, so you must have done it for that good feeling.”

Sober corrects that to want one’s desires satisfied means merely that he wants their propositional contents to come true. To want one’s desires satisfied is not the same as wanting the feeling of satisfaction that sometimes accompanies a satisfied desire.

The Untestability Challenge

Critics often claim egoism is unscientific because egoists re-interpret every selfless act into a selfish one.

For example, consider the soldier in a foxhole who throws himself on a grenade to save the lives of his comrades. The egoist may argue that the soldier realizes that he would rather die than suffer the guilt if he saved himself and allowed his friends to perish.

Sober argues that Egoism is an “Ism”. It does not provide specific explanations for behaviours, but merely indicates the kind of explanation that all behaviours will have. Also, specific egoistic explanations ARE testable. For example, donating money to charity (to impress business contacts vs anonymously).

Psychological Hedonism is the position to which egoists standardly retreat. If external benefits don’t suffice to explain, one invokes internal, psychological benefits instead.

Against Butler’s Stone

Butler’s Stone: Pleasure is the byproduct of satisfying a desire for something else.

Although some pleasures are the result of a desire’s being satisfied, others are not. One can enjoy the smell of violets without having formed the desire to smell a flower, or something sweet.

The Paradox of Hedonism

The Paradox of Hedonism states that if you obsess solely over getting happiness, you won't get it. Happiness comes as a byproduct of engaging in real, meaningful activities.

Sober refutes this by explaining that Hedonism says pleasure is the ultimate end goal, but it doesn't forbid pursuing everyday activities as a means to get there. Even if chasing pleasure directly is a bad strategy, that only shows hedonism is unwise, not that it's false.

The Experience Machine

Robert Nozick asked us to imagine a computer that can give you any pleasure experience you want while you float in a tank. Once plugged in, you forget it's a simulation and believe you are living your dream life.

Most people would not take the chance to plug in for the rest of their life. They care about actually doing real things, not just having the sensation of doing them. If hedonism were true, everyone would choose the machine because it guarantees maximum pleasure.

Hedonists try to explain this by saying that the moment of anxiety right before plugging in is so painful that it outweighs a lifetime of virtual bliss. Sober's rebuttal is that if someone offered you \$5000 to spend 10 seconds believing you were about to plug into the machine forever, you would easily accept.

Sober argues that people refuse the machine because of pleasure and pain during the decision process itself. Deliberation is guided, not so much by beliefs about which actions will bring future pleasure, but by the pleasure and pain that accompany certain thoughts during the deliberation process itself.

Parsimony || Ockham's Razor

Defenders of psychological egoism argue that egoism is simpler than motivational pluralism because it posits only one type of ultimate desire (self-desire), whereas pluralism posits two (self-interest and altruism).

Sober argues that while an egoist has a shorter list of ultimate desires than a pluralist, but the egoist has a longer list of causal beliefs. For this reason, it is unclear why psychological egoism should be regarded as the more parsimonious theory.

The Evolutionary Argument

Sober treats psychological motives as mechanisms shaped by natural selection to trigger adaptive behaviours like human parental care. Consider a simple organism selecting food. It could rely on a direct strategy (protein detector) or an indirect strategy (colour detection, if proteins is always red and poison is always green). Whenever the target trait and the indirect cue are less than perfectly correlated, a direct mechanism is inherently more reliable than an indirect one.

Consider a parent learning their child has fallen through ice on a frozen lake. An altruistic parent is moved directly by the belief that the child needs help. By contrast, a hedonistic parent acts indirectly, driven by the anxiety and fear caused by the news. Because the hedonist's reaction depends on feeling sufficient emotional distress to force action, it comes in last in terms of reliability. Natural selection favours mechanisms directed at evolutionary fitness and child survival rather than peripheral states of personal consciousness alone.

As a result, motivational pluralism functions as the most reliable mechanism. Because humans possess the cognitive capability to form mental representations about their children's welfare, natural selection had no reason to limit motivation to an indirect, self-interested strategy.

Ethical Egoism

Ethical Egoism is a normative theory. It argues that people should actively pursue their own self-interest as their primary moral duty. However, if everyone starts pursuing their own self-interest, then it might lead to chaos. Pure, uncoordinated self-interest can be self-defeating and socially destructive.

Hedonism

Hedonism is the belief that pleasure is the ultimate good.

Folk Hedonism

Folk Hedonism is the basic, unscientific, everyday view of pleasure. Pleasure is all that we should pursue. Under this simple view, “pleasure” is defined purely subjectively as “what I like”. It has no reason or rhyme.

This can be compared to the Freudian concept of the “Id”, which is the primitive, instinctive part of the human psyche that operates on the “pleasure principle”, demanding immediate gratification of basic desires without any logical or moral filter.

Moral Psychology

Moral psychology is the study of how our minds actually function when making moral decisions. For any ethical theory to work, it must be based on a realistic moral psychology. A functioning human agent must possess **temporal continuity, coherence, and reasonableness** to navigate the world.

Folk Hedonism is purely chaotic and acts like the Freudian “Id” (lacking all three properties), so it cannot serve as a psychological foundation for living a coherent moral life.

Jeremy Bentham + The Nature of Motivation

He proposed both psychological and ethical hedonism.

To understand how we are motivated to act, we must ask whether our actions are simply “causally governed” by physical brain chemistry or social conditioning (determinism), or whether our conscious intentions actually play a role in driving our behaviour.

“What is the difference between the fact that my arm is raised and the fact that I raise my arm?”

Bentham wanted to understand what internal forces drive an intentional, minded action.

Psychological Hedonism

Psychological Hedonism is a descriptive theory.

Bentham argued that human beings are naturally motivated only by the “maximization of pleasure and avoidance of pain”. Every intentional action we take is designed to gain pleasure or escape pain.

Ethical Hedonism

Ethical Hedonism is a normative theory.

Because pleasure is the only things that is inherently good, we “should indulge in the actions which maximise pleasure and minimise pain”.

■ How do we know which actions will achieve this?

We look at their consequences. This makes ethical hedonism a form of Consequentialism.

Under this view, the moral value or “utility” of any act is determined entirely by its outcome: its benefits and its costs. When deciding whether to act or which act to undertake, a person must calculate as best as he can the pains and pleasures that may reasonably be expected to come by the acts under consideration.

Hedonistic Calculus

1. **Intensity:** How strong or powerful is the pleasure or pain?
2. **Duration:** How long will the pleasure or pain last?
3. **Certainty:** How likely is it that the pleasure or pain will actually occur?
4. **Propinquity:** How soon will the pleasure happen?
5. **Fecundity:** What is the likelihood that this pleasure will lead to further pleasure?
6. **Purity:** How free is the pleasure from subsequent pain?
7. **Extent:** How many other people will be affected by this pleasure or pain?

Quantitative vs. Qualitative Hedonism

Is all pleasure equal?

Watching a movie might give you high immediate pleasure (propinquity and intensity), but preparing for an exam has higher fecundity and purity.

Bentham's Quantitative Hedonism

He believed that all pleasure are equal in kind. If a childish game produces the same quantity of pleasure as reading a great work of philosophy, then they are morally equal. He rejected the idea that intellectual pleasures are inherently “better” than physical ones.

John Stuart Mills' Qualitative Hedonism

He argued that there are “higher” (intellectual and moral) and “lower” (merely physical) pleasures. Intellectual and artistic pleasures are inherently superior in quality, even if they are harder to achieve.

Butler's Stone (Critique of Hedonism)

Joseph Butler argues that “hedonism gets the psychological cart before the horse”. Hedonists claim that we perform actions because we desire the pleasure they will bring us. Butler argues that **pleasure is actually the byproduct of satisfying a desire for something else**. We only get happiness or pleasure from an object or action because we already value that object, action, or person for their own sake.

“There could be no enjoyment or delight from one thing more than another, from eating food more than from swallowing a stone, if there were not an affection or appetite to one thing more than another.”

Consider the example of nursing a terminally ill person. Under Jeremy Bentham's Hedonistic calculus, a person should avoid nursing a terminally ill patient because the intense physical labour and emotional grief of the experience would calculate as a net loss of pleasure and a surplus of pain.

Under Butler's Stone, we perform this care because we fundamentally value relieving the patient's suffering for its own sake, proving that any feelings of fulfillment we gain are merely the secondary by-products of satisfying a pre-existing, altruistic desire.

Utilitarianism

The core idea is that whether actions are morally right or wrong depend on their effects.

Utilitarians believe that the purpose of morality is to make life better by increasing the good (such as pleasure, happiness and well-being) in the world and decreasing the bad.

It is a **normative theory** about how we should evaluate a wide range of things that involve choices that people face.

It is a form of **consequentialism** because it rests on the idea that it is the consequences or results of actions, laws, policies, etc. that determine whether they are good or bad or right or wrong.

In the language of utilitarians, we should choose the option that “maximises utility”, i.e. that action or policy that produces the maximum amount of good for the maximum amount of people. Utilitarians focus on the happiness of a group over that of an individual.

Utilitarianism includes the important idea that when we calculate the utility of actions, laws or policies, we must do so from an **impartial perspective** and not from a partial perspective that favours us, our friends, or others we especially care about.

Act Utilitarianism

Act utilitarians believe that whenever we are deciding what to do, we should perform the action that will create the greatest net utility.

They **reject rigid rule-based moralities** that identify whole classes of actions as right or wrong (for example, stealing is bad or lying is bad). They argue that it is a mistake to treat whole classes of actions as right or wrong because the effects of actions differ when they are done in different contexts and morality must focus on the likely effects of individual actions.

Act utilitarians acknowledge that it may be useful to have moral rules that are “rules of thumb” that describe what is generally right or wrong, but they insist that whenever people can do more good by violating a rule rather than obeying, they should violate the rule.

Utilitarianism claims objectivity of moral judgements.

Act Utilitarianism provides a method for showing which moral beliefs are true and which are false.

It’s okay to kill one Hitler if his murder saves the lives of many people.

Criticism of Act Utilitarianism

■ The Wrong Answer Objection

If a judge can prevent riots that will cause many deaths only by convicting an innocent person of a crime and imposing a severe punishment on that person, act utilitarianism implies that the judge should convict and punish the innocent person.

If a doctor can save five people from death by killing one healthy person and using that person’s organs for life-saving transplants, then act utilitarianism implies that the doctor should kill the one person to save five.

■ The Undermining Trust Objection

If, in cases like the ones described above, judges, doctors, and promise-makers are committed to doing whatever maximizes well-being, then no one will be able to trust that judges will act according to the law, that doctors will not use the organs of one patient to benefit others, and that promise-makers will keep their promises.

■ Partiality and “Too Demanding” Objection

Whenever people want to buy something for themselves or for a friend or family member, they must first determine whether they could create more well-being by donating their money to other causes. If better can be done by helping strangers than by purchasing things for oneself or people one personally cares about, then act utilitarianism requires us to use the money to help strangers in need.

Rule Utilitarianism

People are bad at judging a situation, hence we should focus on rules for promoting net happiness than on acts. Rules help in producing overall utility than just leaving things to the whims of people.

For example, traffic rules help people easily judge a situation without huge cognitive load and confusion.

Rules cannot be rigid and exceptions can be made. A should follow rule B except in x,y,z situations.

If a judge punishes an innocent person or a doctor kills a person to save more people it will result in the distrust of judicial or medical system leading to diminishing of the overall utility; hence, such an act will not lead to the maximization of utility.

Criticism of Rule Utilitarianism

- It remains unclear whether animal sentience is fully valued, which complicates standard human practices or risks arbitrary exclusion.
- It judges morality strictly by outcomes rather than motives, unfairly penalizing good-faith actions that result in unexpected harm.
- Because commitments are only kept when they maximize net utility, social and interpersonal trust breaks down.
- Prioritizing the majority's aggregate happiness allows minority rights and basic justice to be sacrificed.
- It fails morally compared to Gandhi's Sarvodaya, which demands the upliftment and protection of every individual rather than just the greatest number.

Consequentialism vs. Deontology Debate

Consequentialism is the view that the morality of an action should be judged solely by its consequences. For consequentialists, what matters ethically is the outcomes that result from our choices and behaviours. Utilitarianism and ethical egoism are forms of consequentialism.

Deontology, by contrast, judges the morality of actions based on their adherence to rules, duties, or obligations. Certain actions are intrinsically right or wrong regardless of their consequences. The right action is the one that follows moral rules or fulfills moral duties. It has its roots in notions of divine law and absolute moral commandments found in many religions.

The Trolley Problem

The consequentialist approach would say that, ethically, you should push the man. The outcome of this action results in one death instead of five, producing the best overall consequences. The fact that you have to actively kill someone, rather than passively allow deaths to occur, is not ethically relevant from a purely consequentialist view. Only the number of lives saved matters.

The deontological approach, however, would typically say that pushing the man is morally wrong. Most deontological theories include a prohibition on murder (actively and intentionally killing an innocent person). The fact that this murder saves a net four lives doesn't change its inherent wrongness. We have a duty not to use people merely as a means to an end, even if that end is good. There's also often seen to be a morally relevant distinction between killing and letting die.

Strengths and Weaknesses

Consequentialism offers a flexible framework that prioritizes real-world impact, impartiality, and overall well-being. However, predicting long-term outcomes is inherently difficult, and its strict focus on results can problematically justify violating individual rights for the "greater good".

Conversely, deontology provides clear, stable moral rules that strongly protect human dignity and account for personal intentions. Yet, its rigid adherence to absolute rules can cause ethical conflicts and disastrous consequences when context is completely ignored.

[Thomas Nagel] Altruism

Altruism is the genuine concern for the well-being of others that operates independently of personal gain, ulterior motives, or expectations or reciprocity.

The competing view is psychological egoism. Nagel argues against psychological egoism by asserting that altruism is neither an irrational emotional impulse nor a contingent psychological desire, but rather a rational requirement on human action.

Nagel's account relies on **Moral Cognitivism** (moral judgements express beliefs capable of being true or false), **Rationalism** (moral requirements are derived from reason), and **Value Realism** (values exist objectively in the world).

Reason as Motivation

Nagel identifies a pervasive assumption in moral philosophy that every action must be impelled by an underlying subjective desire i.e., "the belief that an act of mine will benefit someone else can motivate me only because I want his good, or else want something which involves it".

Nagel rejects the claim that a prior desire is a necessary precondition for every rational action. While a desire may be present when one acts altruistically, the desire is not the fundamental basis of the motivation. Instead, the desire is motivated by reasons provided by the external situation and the needs of others. Therefore, desire is not the primary source of motivation; reason itself generates the relevant desire.

Reason enables us to justify choosing A over B. Without a rational justification, we cannot coherently prefer A to B. If X performs an action Y, it is because he has a reason to do so. As rational beings, our actions are guided not merely by impulse but by the recognition of reasons.

Prudence

Prudence means the ability to govern and discipline oneself through reason, combined with careful good judgement to avoid unnecessary risks or danger. Nagel argues that altruism is a rational requirement on human conduct, analogous to prudence.

We are not solely guided by pleasure. We are also guided by our future interests. We perceive ourselves as temporally extended beings and our identity is the unity of past, present and future. Hence, we are also guided by prudence. For example, deciding health habits today to maintain well-being in old age. It also shows that we have the psychological capacity to withdraw from our immediate interests and observe ourselves from an objective point of view.

Subjective vs Objective Reasons

- Subjective reasons are principles where the reason for acting contains an essential reference to the person who has the reason.
- Objective reasons are principles where the reason can be formulated without any essential reference to the specific identity of the actor.

"The thesis which I propose to defend is simply that the only acceptable reasons are objective ones; even if one operates successfully with a subjective principle, one must be able to back it up with an objective principle yielding those same reasons as well as (presumably) others."

For example, when a victim asks "How would you like it if someone did that to you?", the perpetrator is forced to step outside their own subjective viewpoint. You do not stop making fun of the person merely because of a sudden emotional impulse or feeling. You stop because you realise that if humiliation is objectively bad, you cannot rationally justify your own conduct.

Nagel argues that moral statements are not emotive in nature, rather they have an objective validity which gives us reason to act.

Subjective reasons are based on personal concerns and cannot have objective validity as they may be based on biases. Objective reasons are impersonal and a moral agent can perceive the situation impartially.

Morality therefore is a fundamental feature of rationality, as we are motivated by reason to act on principles which can be recognised from an impersonal and objective standpoint.

Values exist independent of our beliefs and subjective feelings. They are an objective feature of the world that can be recognised through reason. Hence, we have moral obligations and we cannot dismiss them as mere social or cultural constructions.

Altruism depends on the recognition of the reality of the other persons and considering myself existing in the same way as other persons exist.

Rational analysis helps us to determine the validity or invalidity of any moral claim. For example, we should not abet suicide. It has an objective validity as any rational person would not like to harm life from an impartial and impersonal point of view.

Nagel is a moral cognitivist as he believes that moral statements express beliefs that can be true or false. They are not just expressions of sentiments.

In the absence of any objective criteria, any personal reason can qualify as a moral claim.

The Gouty Toes and Heel Argument || Refuting Ethical Egoism

An egoist maintains that a person's pain gives that person a reason to act, but gives no direct reason to anyone else.

The pain which gives him a reason to remove his gouty toes from under another person's heel does not in itself give the other person reason to remove the heel, since it is not his pain.

When the perpetrator does not remove his heel, the victim feels resentment. Resentment embodies the judgement that another is failing to act on reasons.

It is difficult to resist the tendency to objectify the negative value which one assigns to pain, or would assign to it if one experienced it, regarding the identity of its owner as irrelevant.

Hence, if we think that the other person has a reason to remove his heel, it comes from the recognition of the other person's pain which is possible when taking an impersonal standpoint.

Personal vs Impersonal Standpoint

- Personal standpoints view the world from a vantage point within it.
- Impersonal standpoints view the world neutrally, without specifying one's own location or identity within the description.

Altruism depends on stepping outside one's personal perspective to recognise that one exists merely as one person among others in a shared world.

A complete impersonal description of a situation specifies all facts without referencing their identity.

Adding the first-person belief "I am T.N." supplies a location premise. It informs an agent where they are situated within the scene and alters how the world is subjectively conceived but it does not introduce new facts regarding what is actually taking place.

- "I should leave the building before the bomb goes off"
- "T.N. should leave the building before the bomb goes off"

The fundamental reason to escape a bomb derives entirely from the objective danger to human life, not from the contingent fact that the person in danger happens to be “me” or happens to be named T.N.

This proves that practical reasons derive from objective conditions rather than any special status attached to the first-person “me”.

Solipsism

- **Metaphysical solipsism** is the doctrine that only oneself and one’s own mental states exist, denying meaning to the claim that other minds experience consciousness.
- **Practical solipsism** occurs when an agent is unable or unwilling to apply practical, normative judgments to other people in the exact same sense in which they apply them to themselves.
- **Realism** is the position that certain things exist independently of our minds, beliefs, or subjective perceptions.

While an individual might entertain theoretical skepticism about other minds at a metaphysical level, Nagel insists that we must operate as moral realists in the normative sphere. Failing to adopt moral realism renders it impossible to explain or justify shared moral values and interpersonal duties.

[Andrew Ward] Starting with Kant

Deontology

Deontology is a duty-based / intention-based ethical theory. What matters morally is acting on the right principle, not producing good outcomes.

A duty is an action performed on a principle; specifically, a principle that could apply **universally**. How do we arrive at the right principle? The answer is consistency and fairness. Ask “what if everyone did that?”

It is unfair for one person to make an exception for themselves while expecting everyone else to follow the rule. This is both unfair and inconsistent, because if everyone made exceptions, the practice would collapse and there would be no scope for order.

Acting from Duty vs. Acting from Inclination

Kant claims that an action motivated solely by desire or inclination, even a good / kind desire, has no genuine moral worth, even if it produces a morally good result. Only actions performed irrespective of whether they achieve any desired end have moral worth.

Consider the sympathetic philanthropist example. A person who helps others purely because they have a warm, sympathetic temperament, and takes an inner pleasure in it, is acting *in conformity with duty but not for the sake of duty*. So the act has no moral worth, however admirable it looks. If this same person loses all natural sympathy (overcome by their own sorrows) and still helps the person purely because they recognise it is their duty, then for the first time his action has its genuine moral worth.

Kant argues that all desires and inclinations are forms of self-love. They are motivated by the pleasure or avoidance of pain that the action brings to the agent, directly or indirectly. Since acting from self-love can never have moral worth, and inclination-based action is always a form of self-love, only action from duty alone (independent of all inclination) can be moral.

Ward notes a common objection that it seems wrong to say a purely benevolent act has no moral worth. Hume says that not all desires are reducible to self-love. Following Butler, Hume argues that we have genuine altruistic desires that are felt prior to self-love, not derived from it. Ward considers that perhaps Kant’s point isn’t that inclinations are all self-love, but that morality must be based on what is common to all possible rational beings, and no particular desire (even altruistic ones) is shared by every rational beings, whereas **reason** is.

Hypothetical vs. Categorical Imperatives

Hypothetical imperatives are “if-then” imperatives. If you want X, then do Y. They are premised on desires. If you don’t want X, you are not obliged to do Y.

Categorical imperatives are imperatives that holds regardless of your desires. According to Kant, these are your duties and you are obliged to do them unconditionally.

Moral duties are categorical imperatives.

In the Kantian view, moral “ought” judgements arise immediately from reason. They are categorical. By contrast, according to Hume, all ought judgements (including moral ones) arise only mediately, conditional on some desire. They are hypothetical. Reason in the Humean picture only captures the best means to a desired end; it never sets the end itself or motivates independently.

Maxims

A maxim is a practical principle which a rational being is himself acting on or at least seriously proposing to act on. It is subjective. It is a rule an agent actually adopts, as opposed to an objective practical principle (a law that holds for all rational agents whether or not anyone follows it).

A maxim can be moral or immoral. This is what the categorical imperative test is for.

- The **content (matter)** of a principle is what it is about. E.g., relieving suffering, or advancing one's own status. A principle motivating via its content is a material principle, and per Kant, all material principles motivate only through the pleasure / pain they bring the agent. Hence, they can never yield moral worth.
- The **form (structure)** of a principle is just whether it's suitable to be willed as a universal law. A formal principle motivates independent of pleasure / pain and hence independent of desire. Only a formal principle (i.e., the moral law itself) can generate genuine moral worth.

A maxim includes both the type of act and the ground / motive. This matters enormously for how the categorical imperative is applied. The same type of act can be permissible or forbidden depending on the motive specified in the maxim.

The Will

The will is a rational being's capacity to be motivated by its consciousness of rules of action. Only beings that can formulate and act on maxims can be moral agents, because only reason can formulate a principle / rule of action.

What further conditions must a rational being meet to be capable of acting morally? The will must be capable of autonomy.

Autonomy vs. Heteronomy of the Will

- **Autonomy:** Reason employs the categorical imperative to determine what we ought to do, and motivates the will by itself. The will is motivated by the **self-legislation** of reason, operating independently of desires / inclinations.
- **Heteronomy:** Motivation comes not from reason but from the agent's desires and inclinations. Reason's only role is to calculate the best means to a desired end.

Only autonomous action has moral worth. Under heteronomy, even if the resulting act conforms to duty, it is not done for the sake of duty, so it has no moral worth.

This capacity to generate our own laws / ends rather than merely acting on ends nature hands us via instinct and desire is what Kant calls free will.

A free will is not determined by outside / alien causes yet is itself a cause of action. Causality requires law-governed behaviour. A free will must be governed by a law of its own making, not by external causes like desires. Since desires / inclinations are "alien causes" (they arise independently of reason), a will governed by them is not free.

The only rule that excludes determination by desire is the categorical imperative. Therefore, Kant concludes that a free will and a will under the moral law are one and the same.

Kant as a rationalist says that all moral "ought" judgements come immediately from reason (categorical imperatives and autonomy).

Hume as an empiricist says that all "ought" judgements are conditional on desire (hypothetical imperatives) and reason only finds means to desired ends (heteronomy).

Kant distinguishes the phenomenal world (world of appearances, spatio-temporal, governed by deterministic natural causation) from the noumenal world (things as they are in themselves, non-spatial, non-temporal). In the phenomenal world alone, every action would be caused by prior desires / inclinations (strict determinism), leaving no room for freedom and thus no room for morality. But if we can also conceive of ourselves as belonging to the noumenal world, then it is at least logically possible that our will can be motivated by reason alone, independent of natural / causal determination, and freedom and autonomy become logically possible.

Kant does not claim to prove theoretically that we are free. Instead, he offers a practical proof. From a practical point of view, we must regard ourselves as free, because we unmistakably do acknowledge the supreme authority of the moral law over our actions. We praise / blame ourselves as though we could have acted otherwise on the basis of reason. From a practical point of view, we really are free.

Reason

Reason determines the form, not the content, of maxims.

Ethical rationalists (Kant) believe that morality is founded on reason alone. Ethical empiricists (Hume) believe that morality must be founded on sentiment / feeling as well as reason. Ward notes that both sides agree reason alone provides no feelings of pleasure / pain. The disagreement is whether reason alone can still motivate the will without feeling.

Reason does not produce ordinary desire-based feelings, but it does produce a special feeling (respect for the moral law) as the effect of reason's opposition to inclination, not as its cause.

Reason is what all possible rational beings have in common. Desires / inclinations are not shared by all rational beings so only a reason-based principle (the categorical imperative) can hold universally for every rational being.

The Moral Law

Act only on that maxim [rule] through which you can at the same time will that it should become a universal law.

1. Identify the maxim / rule governing your proposed action.
2. Ask: could you universalize this maxim without contradiction?
3. If you cannot universalize it without contradiction, then acting on it is inconsistent, irrational and unfair, and therefore immoral.

If the maxim is universalizable, we are acting on reasons everyone could stand behind. This is a test of both fairness (making no exception for yourself) and consistency (your goal remains compatible with everyone else acting the same way).

Consider the Golden Rule: "Do unto others as you would have them do unto you". Is this a test of consistency? It actually makes morality depend on personal desires / tastes. If you like being hit, then does that permit you to hit others?

Kant summarises that "I ought never to act except in such a way that I can also will that my maxim should become a universal law."

Hence, Kant argues that the rightness of an action depends on its maxim and the morality of an action has nothing to do with its results. It has to do with our intentions and reasons for action (maxims).

Since moral duties are categorical imperatives, **we are rational when we are moral, and irrational when we are immoral.**

The Feeling of Respect

Kant says we must act from reason alone, yet also says acting from duty requires respect for the moral law, and respect is a feeling.

Respect is not an ordinary, desire-based feeling that precedes and causes reason's judgement. Rather, respect is the effect of reason opposing and overriding our desires and inclinations.

Even after establishing that autonomy is possible (via the phenomenal / noumenal distinction), Ward says that Kant still cannot fully explain how pure reason, by itself, manages to actually override sensuous desires in a given case.

Kant treats our recognition of the moral law's authority as an ultimate "fact of reason" and not something derivable from anything more basic, but a feature of our moral consciousness that we cannot further justify or explain, only describe.

We cannot explain how reason motivates, but our practice - the fact that we do hold ourselves and others responsible for acting from duty - proves that it does.

The Principle of Humanity

Act in such a way that you always treat humanity [other persons] never simply as a means, but always at the same time as an end.

Humanity has intrinsic value, characterised by rationality and autonomy. To "use" someone merely as a tool / instrument is to dishonour their identity and to fail to respect the very feature that gives them worth.

We deserve to be treated as "ends in ourselves" because, through reason, we are capable of creating our own ends / purposes (free will), rather than merely following ends given to us by instinct / nature. This capacity for self-legislation is what makes us autonomous, rational agents worthy of respect as ends, not mere means.

Duty for Duty's Sake

An act has moral worth only if performed for the sake of duty, not merely in conformity with duty.

Acting for the sake of duty means that the will is motivated by the mere recognition that the maxim can be willed as a universal law (the categorical imperative), not by any desire for a resulting end, and not even by the pleasure of doing a good deed.

This requires autonomy of the will (self-legislation through reason) rather than heteronomy (motivation by desire / inclination).

The feeling of respect is how this rational motivation becomes conscious to us, but respect is the effect, not the cause, of reason's authority.

Doing one's duty "for its own sake" is possible only because we can (from a practical point of view) regard ourselves as free, existing as members of the noumenal world and not wholly determined by the phenomenal, causally-determined world of desires.

Ultimately, that we are bound to act for duty's sake is, for Kant, an unprovable but undeniable "fact of reason".

[Aristotle] Virtue Ethics

Virtue Ethics are a shift in perspective from what is morally right / wrong or good / bad to how we ought to live our lives.

We don't perform right actions by first figuring out the correct actions and then doing it. Instead, we perform right actions by becoming the right kind of person: a virtuous person. **Try to become a virtuous person, and good actions will follow.**

Socrates, unlike his predecessors, shunned speculation about the natural world and focused exclusively on ethics. His brand of ethics is what we now call "virtue ethics," which, as the name suggests, entails an interest in the character of a moral agent and how it relates to his overall wellbeing. In general, it asks the question how one should live one's life, with an eye to living well through managing one's character.

Plato inherited this project from Socrates, and Aristotle inherited it from Plato.

Aristotle's Methodology

Aristotle thought that every science has a **domain of objects** that it studies, and posits "**first principles**" for the domain which explain important features of its objects.

Since the domain relevant to ethics is human lives and the feature to be explained is their goodness, what ethics needs to posit as a first principle is the highest human good or *summum bonum*. Once we have our first principle, claims Aristotle, we will be able to aim at bringing this good life into being, both for ourselves and our fellow human beings.

The Guiding Assumptions about Eudaimonia

The highest good, then, is a goal that we try to bring about. According to Aristotle, it is the highest good because it is chosen for its own sake, and it is for its sake that everything else is chosen.

1. Goods are ranked teleologically, so that if we choose good x for the sake of good y, and good y for the sake of good z, then good z is the highest good in the series, followed by y and then x.

Aristotle also assumes that all goods are related to each other in this way, so that they form a simple order terminating in a single highest good.

Aristotle calls this highest good eudaimonia.

Eudaimonia translates best as "flourishing". It is not merely pleasure or happiness in one particular endeavor. It consists of fulfilling one's function.

2. **Eudaimonia is teleion.**

This means it is:

- Final = chosen for its own sake, not for the sake of anything further
- Complete = encompassing everything of intrinsic (not instrumental) worth

For instance, Aristotle says we choose "honour, pleasure, reason, and every virtue" for the sake of eudaimonia, but also for their own sakes and not just as means to eudaimonia. So eudaimonia, being teleion, will include these goods as constituents.

3. The summum bonum, though an ideal, should be **something achievable by the average person**, and he objected to Plato's Form of the Good, an occult metaphysical object that somehow makes other things good, for failing to be a thing of this sort. Aristotle claims that eudaimonia will be generally shared by anyone without a wrecked character and with a modicum of care and attention.
4. Eudaimonia is **uniquely and characteristically human**. This assumption is used to rule out a life of pleasure as eudaimonia, because pleasure is not unique to humans. Other animals feel pleasure too.

5. **Eudaimonia must be an activity, not a mere disposition**, like a virtue. Dispositions like virtues are always for the sake of their corresponding activities, whereas eudaimonia is *teleion* (final). Courage is for the sake of courageous action, otherwise it would be useless.

Although we may praise a virtuous person who is somehow incapacitated (e.g., physically disabled in some way that will prevent him from doing virtuous actions), we save our congratulations for those who are courageous *and* act courageously. Thus, eudaimonia must consist in activity, and not a mere disposition.

Eudaimonia is not a subjective mental state, like a feeling of happiness. It is something you do, not something you merely experience.

6. For eudaimonia, Aristotle believed that physical engagement with the world is also necessary. It is thought to be “something of one’s own and not easily taken from one”. What is always up to us, and does not depend on anyone else, is the manner in which we act, as opposed to anything we might achieve or obtain.
7. **Eudaimonia must be self-sufficient** (*autarkês*), defined as lacking nothing that is good. This does not require that the happy person possess every good, but just that he possess every good that would make his life better.

“Self-sufficient” doesn’t mean sufficient for a solitary individual. It includes what is needed for parents, children, spouse, friends, and fellow citizens, since man is by nature a political animal. In the *Politics*, Aristotle compares a human to a game piece: just as a piece is only a game piece within a game, a human is only fully human within human society.

8. Since eudaimonia consists in a certain sort of activity, then the longer one lives while engaged in this activity the better. The idea is that one cannot be called happy based on a short period of one’s life. So one needs to wait until the end to see how it turns out, not only to see how long it is but also to see whether it remains happy until the end.

This creates a paradox since saying eudaimonia both (a) cannot be increased / augmented and (b) gets better the longer you have it, seems contradictory.

The Function Argument

1. Eudaimonia must be an activity characteristic of humans as humans.
2. A thing’s characteristic activity is its function (*ergon*).
3. Since eudaimonia must be unique to humans (not just characteristic), and pleasure is shared with animals, its function must be something else.
4. Reason and speech distinguish humans from other animals. The human function is activity in accordance with reason.
5. Since eudaimonia is the *summum bonum*, it isn’t just any rational activity, but excellent rational activity.

The word that Aristotle uses for excellence is *aretê*, which often gets translated as “virtue”. In Greek, *aretê* means excellence, usually of a thing in performing its characteristic function as that particular sort of thing.

For instance, if the function of a doctor as a doctor is healing people, then the *aretê* of a doctor as a doctor is healing people well. Likewise, if the function of a human as a human is to act in accordance with reason, then the *aretê* of a human as a human is to do this well.

“Acting in accordance with reason” is ambiguous. It could mean the pure intellectual / contemplative activity of reasoning or acting reasonably / virtuously in everyday life. However, the focus in the beginning of the *Nicomachean Ethics* is clearly on the much more down-to-earth matter of behaving reasonably in everyday life, or in exhibiting virtue of character.

Virtue of Character || The Doctrine of the Mean

Virtue of character is defined as a disposition concerned with choice, lying in a mean relative to us, determined by reason and as the person of practical wisdom would determine it.

Aristotle defines choice as a “deliberate desire of things in our own power” or the desire we get after rationally deliberating on a course of action to undertake that course of action.

So a disposition concerned with choice is a disposition governing the nature of these rational desires.

The claim that this disposition lies in a mean refers to Aristotle’s famous **doctrine of the mean**, according to which virtues of character are characterized by mean states of actions and emotions.

That this mean is “relative to us” means that it is not a simple arithmetic mean but a mean relative to the particular circumstances of the agent.

Temperance is the mean in desire / consumption of food and drink. A “moderate” amount for a very large person would be excessive for the rest of us. Mildness in temper is the mean in feeling anger. What counts as moderate anger varies depending on the provocation / incitement on a given occasion.

The “mean” refers not to the mediocre or the average but to the peak of excellence that is just right, given the situation and the people involved.

Virtue requires training and practice. It is the habit of acting virtuously and valuing virtue for its own sake. This is why moral education matters. Virtue ethics therefore evaluates the person (their character) rather than isolated individual actions.

Practical Wisdom (Phronesis)

Because the mean is relative and context-dependent, it must be pinned down by reason and practical wisdom (the intellectual virtue that lets one “spot” the correct mean in a given situation). Aristotle says we judge the appropriate mean by imagining what a person recognised as having practical wisdom would do in that situation.

Practical wisdom means knowing how to act in a given situation, such that virtue is actually accomplished. Phronesis matters, especially when it’s not a consequentialist theory. It isn’t about calculating outcomes, but about perceiving what the situation calls for.

For example, lying could be demanded of particular situation. Phronesis can require context-sensitive judgment that departs from a fixed rule because the right action depends on circumstances.

This knowledge is attained through life experience and mindfully living.

Cardinal Virtues and Intellectual Virtues

A moral virtue is the state of character in which a person has a habit of choosing the mean between excess and deficiency.

The four cardinal (moral) virtues are: prudence, courage, temperance and justice.

The common element across all moral virtues is conformity with right reasoning. It means taking all relevant aspects of a particular situation into account to reach the correct choice (the sort of choice that an impartial but knowledgeable observer would come to).

Prudence (practical wisdom) is crucial to acquiring the moral virtues. It is the intellectual virtue that makes the moral virtues possible.

Intellectual virtues are developed / acquired dispositions of excellence in the use of one’s mind.

Five especially important intellectual virtues are: science, art, prudence, intuition of first principles, wisdom.

Aristotle's Ethical Naturalism

Ethical naturalism derives ethical conclusions (the specification of the human *summum bonum*) from an objective concept of human nature.

Every species has a characteristic, objectively observable mode of life, and the function of its faculties is the unimpeded expression of that mode of life. Just as a healthy respiratory system permits unimpeded characteristic physical activity, healthy psychological faculties permit unimpeded characteristic psychological activity.

Virtue as Happiness

In Plato's *Republic*, Thrasymachus argues justice is pursuing someone else's advantage while injustice pursues one's own. Virtue (justice) looks like it costs the virtuous person something.

Aristotle responds that the virtuous person is in a state of internal harmony: their rational part governs, and their irrational part (emotional / appetitive) part obeys reason without resistance. Meanwhile, the vicious person is at variance with themselves, because although they know how they should behave, their passions sway them otherwise. As a consequence, vicious people don't enjoy their own company and seek distraction in others to avoid confronting their own misdeeds.

Hence, pursuing injustice for one's own advantage is self-defeating. It comes at the inescapable cost of becoming a bad person. *Eudaimonia* affords the immediate benefit of being pleased with oneself.

Behaving virtuously is an ineliminable, uniquely human part of a good life. One must be good to be well.

Rationality and Pleasure

Aristotle's view is that those pleasures that assist the development and proper use of our rationality should be regarded as right and good. Those that in some way impair or frustrate our rationality must be regarded as suspect.

Aristotle's conception of rationality includes thinking and knowing but also making choices and deciding on activities and all this must be considered, not just from our lives as individuals, but from our lives in the community (the polis), as well.

Pleasure and Virtue

One of the marks of having a habit is that one will find pleasure (as well as ease and regularity) in doing a certain type of action.

Hence, having a specific habit that is a virtue (a morally good habit), a person will actually find it a pleasure to do the right thing, to strike the mean between the extremes, rather than go to excess or deficiency.

In contrast to the view that all or most pleasures are bad, Aristotle argues that **moral maturation** involves growth in feeling pleasure in some pursuits and increasing sensitivity to the ugliness or inappropriateness of other pursuits.

Moral Exemplars

The virtue ethicist is not interested in grounding moral truths but in being a virtuous person. A moral exemplar is a morally outstanding person whom we admire. An important part of our attempt to become more virtuous is learning about, surrounding ourselves by, and trying to emulate moral exemplars. Further, we can discover what the virtues are by looking at the virtues that moral exemplars embody.

Sufficiency of Virtue for Happiness

Is virtue *necessary* for happiness, or also *sufficient*?

Aristotle holds that virtue is necessary but not sufficient for happiness: virtuous activity partly constitutes eudaimonia, but actually exercising virtue also requires external and bodily goods (friends, wealth, health, political standing), so someone stripped of all these by bad fortune can be praised for their character but not congratulated on being happy.

Aristotle calls the idea that a person being tortured is happy “nonsense”, since ethical theory should vindicate common sense rather than override it.